



44 |

**IN A FAST-CHANGING** digital-first world, even nostalgia has a shorter time frame. It was only a few years ago that Indians had started warming up to the idea of giving up on the age-old and unreliable cable TV connections and terrestrial TV that came with a cumbersome antenna setup, in favour of direct-to home (DTH) satellite TV service. In 2006, when Tata Sky launched its DTH service, the company had a clear motive: give Indians a taste of premium viewing with services such as 24x7 customer support, digital video recording (DVR), high-definition picture quality, etc. Today, at least for a few, even pay TV is fast becoming nostalgia because of the onslaught of OTT and a looming bugbear called DD Free Dish.

To counter that, India's largest DTH operator, which is a joint venture between the Tata group and Sky TV (then owned by Rupert Murdoch and now owned globally by The Walt Disney Company), has donned a new name—Tata Play—and a new look. Its brand colours blue and red are now white and pink. But the brand's basic ethos remains unchanged. "We have the same philosophy, same ethos and same obsession for the customer which is what got us here," says Harit Nagpal, MD & CEO, Tata Play. "The only thing that changed a couple of years back was that people started watching beyond television, and we thought since we're distributors of content, we should be medium-agnostic and become aggregators for OTT (over-the-top)

content as well." Tata Sky acted as a distributor/aggregator of just television content while Tata Play offers bundled packs where as a family, someone can watch TV content, someone can watch OTT content and someone can watch the same content on their phone. They will be billed as a family for their entertainment needs from the same vendor instead of 10 different individual subscriptions to keep track of.

In 2019, the company made a foray into OTT with the launch of 'Tata Sky Binge', a platform that brings digital content from multiple apps into TV, but because of its strong DTH brand recall, people would still associate it with just TV. "We realised we needed to do a refresh for the brand so that people start believing that we're distributors of content and not just distributors of TV content," Nagpal explains. In FY19, the company's consolidated profit after tax (PAT) grew 463 per cent to ₹364 crore from ₹64 crore in FY18. Partially offset by the pandemic, the growth couldn't sustain for too long. In FY21, it reported ₹69 crore PAT—marginally crossing its 2017-18 numbers. That's why the name change was probably more survivalist than symbolic.

## THE FREE DISH ONSLAUGHT

India's DTH industry is facing a two-pronged attack from DD Free Dish on one side and OTT on the

other, and the challenge is bigger from Free Dish, which is a free-to-air DTH service owned by public service broadcaster Prasar Bharati with around 52 million users in India, according to Media Partners Asia, a research, advisory and consulting firm. With more than 100 TV channels on board, Free Dish, launched in 2004, has a growing presence in rural households despite a massive shift towards online streaming platforms. During the pandemic, millions of DTH customers dropped their subscriptions. But Nagpal believes that was not because of OTT's surge. "Our data shows that it's not the person subscribing to Netflix who has switched off his TV subscription. Service-sector employees from villages who had lower-end plans were intermittently switching on during the pandemic to economise on their expenses," says Nagpal.

Free Dish has long been a growth deterrent for DTH players like Tata Sky and Airtel, but many believe that it is an important tool for people at the lower end of the spectrum to start with free TV, get into the content-watching habit, and then upgrade to better quality pay TV. "There are around 125 million households that don't even have a TV today. It's a very nice pool for us to poach from and get 3-5 million subscribers every year. The bigger this pool gets, the better it is for us. Free-to-air does the job of making people buy TVs. It's a step-wise transition. It's not competition but a source of customers for us," says Nagpal.

Utkarsh Sinha, Managing Director of advisory firm Bexley Advisors, says India is a leapfrog nation and might not evolve linearly like it's been expected. "One of the biggest manifestations of this is in the OTT space. Given the fact that India became a mobile-first country, the entertainment wallet is limited. There are a lot of content companies vying for the same audience. Mil-

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